THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

Read it like a storybook: one step on each page, a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. The last room trains your ears.

THE ROOMS

1 · Sitting and hands
2 · The keyboard
3 · Finger numbers
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · The beat
6 · Notes: crotchet and minim
7 · Notes: dotted minim and semibreve
8 · Loud and soft
9 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · THE STORY

Sitting and hands

HEAR THE STORY

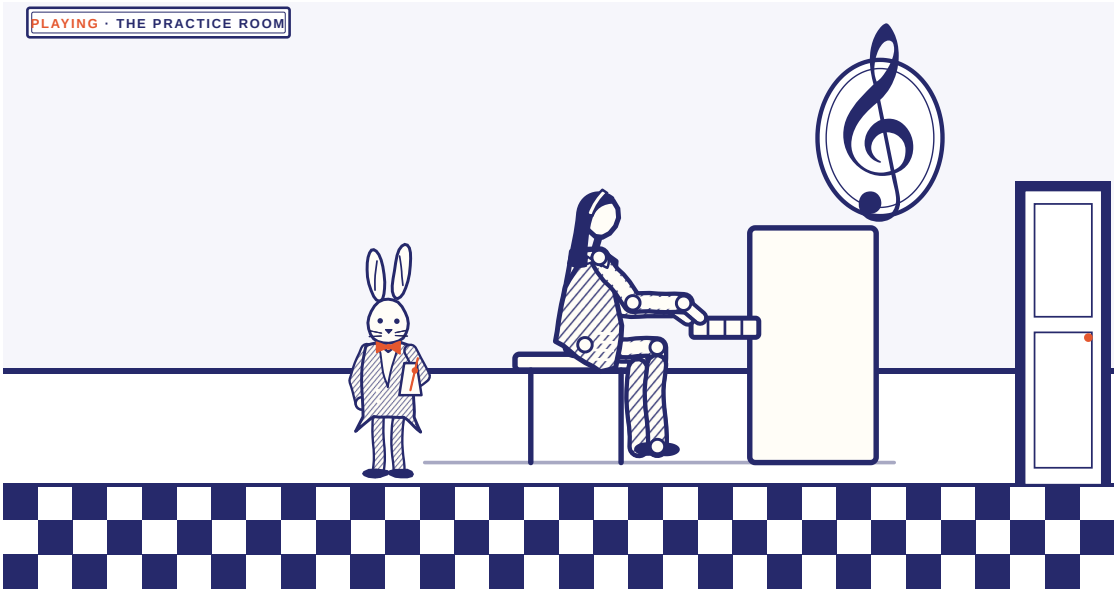


Plate I. Clara arrives. The Butler has already seen to the stool.

Clara has come to live in a tall house full of music. Before she may play a single note, the **Butler** asks her to sit down. “A pianist,” he says, “begins with the chair.”

Then he shows her, one thing at a time. **Sit on the front half** of the stool. **Feet flat** on the floor. **Back tall**, shoulders soft. And the stool just high enough that your **forearms are level with the keys**, like a table top.

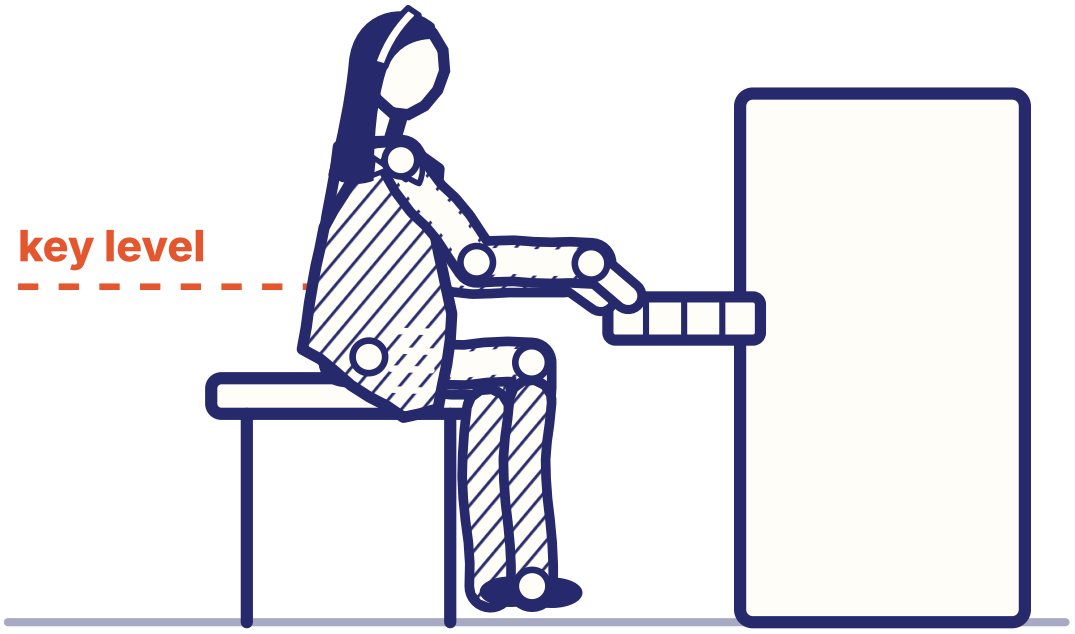
Try it at the piano

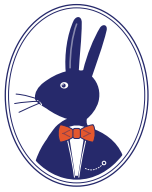
1. Sit at the piano and check the four things, one by one: front half, feet flat, back tall, arms level with the keys. ○

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Sitting and hands

SCAN TO LISTEN





Sit tall on the front half of the stool, with both **feet flat** on the floor.

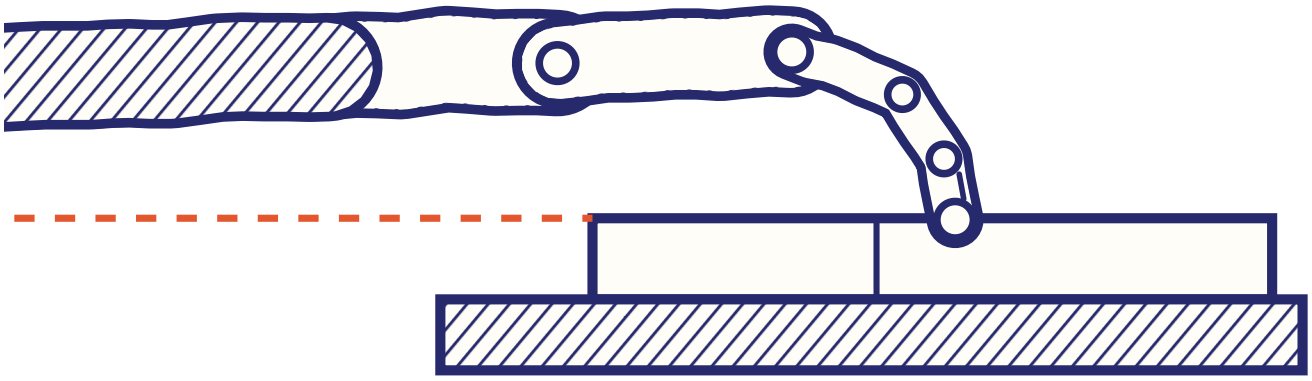
Your arms float out in front, **level with the keys**, like a table top.

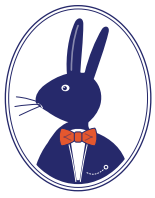
Try it

1 Sit down. Lift your shoulders up to your ears, then let them drop.

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

Sitting and hands





Hold a small ball in your hand. That **round shape** is your playing hand.

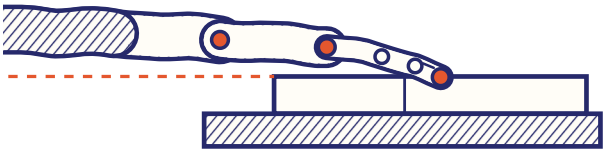
Your knuckles stand up like a **bridge**, and you play on your **fingertips**.

Try it at the piano

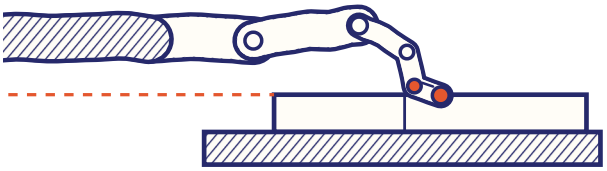
1. Hold a ball or an orange. Put your hand on the keys without changing its shape.

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

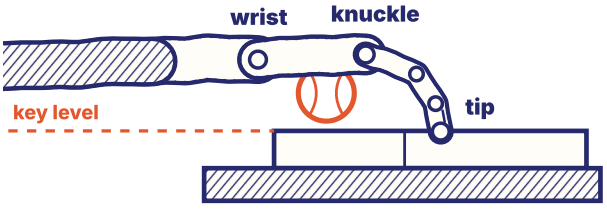
Sitting and hands



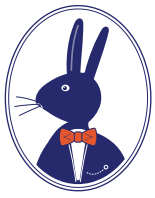
× flat



× fallen in



✓ round



A **flat** hand is fast asleep. A bridge that has **fallen in** cannot carry anything.

The **round** hand can play all day.

Try it

1. Make the flat hand, then the fallen bridge, then the round hand. Feel the difference.

ROOM 1 · HOW IT ENDED

Sitting and hands

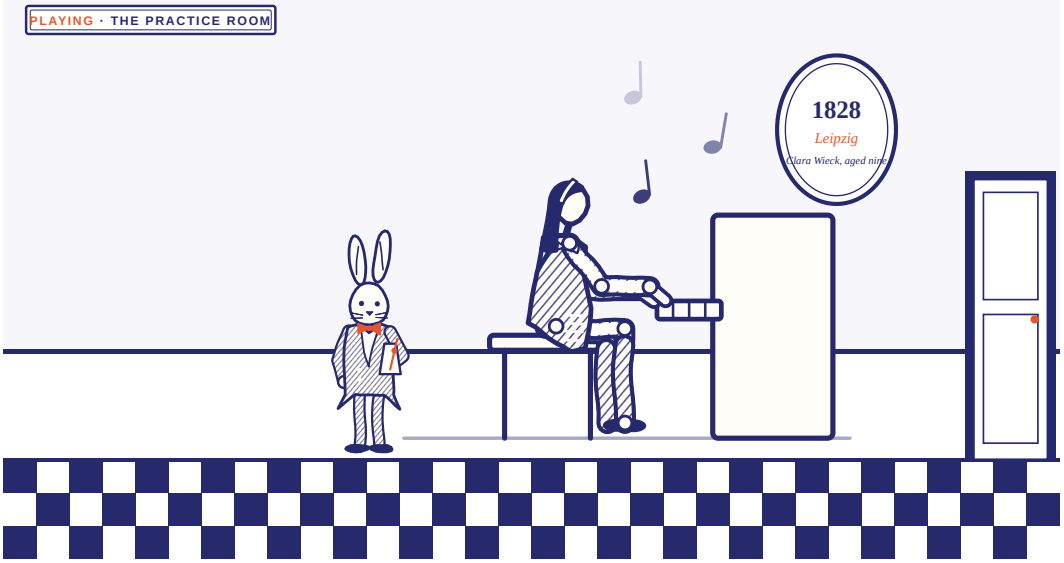


Plate I. Another Clara, aged nine, playing in public for the first time.

Nearly two hundred years ago another girl called **Clara**, Clara Wieck, played in public for the first time, at the Gewandhaus concert hall in Leipzig. She was nine years old.

She grew up to be one of the great pianists of her time, Clara Schumann. She, too, had to start at the beginning.

Try it at the piano

1 Sit at the piano and check three things before you play: feet flat, back tall, arms level with the keys. ○

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

That night, from the empty music room, Clara heard a single note. When she looked, all eighty-eight keys lay perfectly still. Which one had it been?

ROOM 2 · THE STORY

The keyboard

HEAR THE STORY

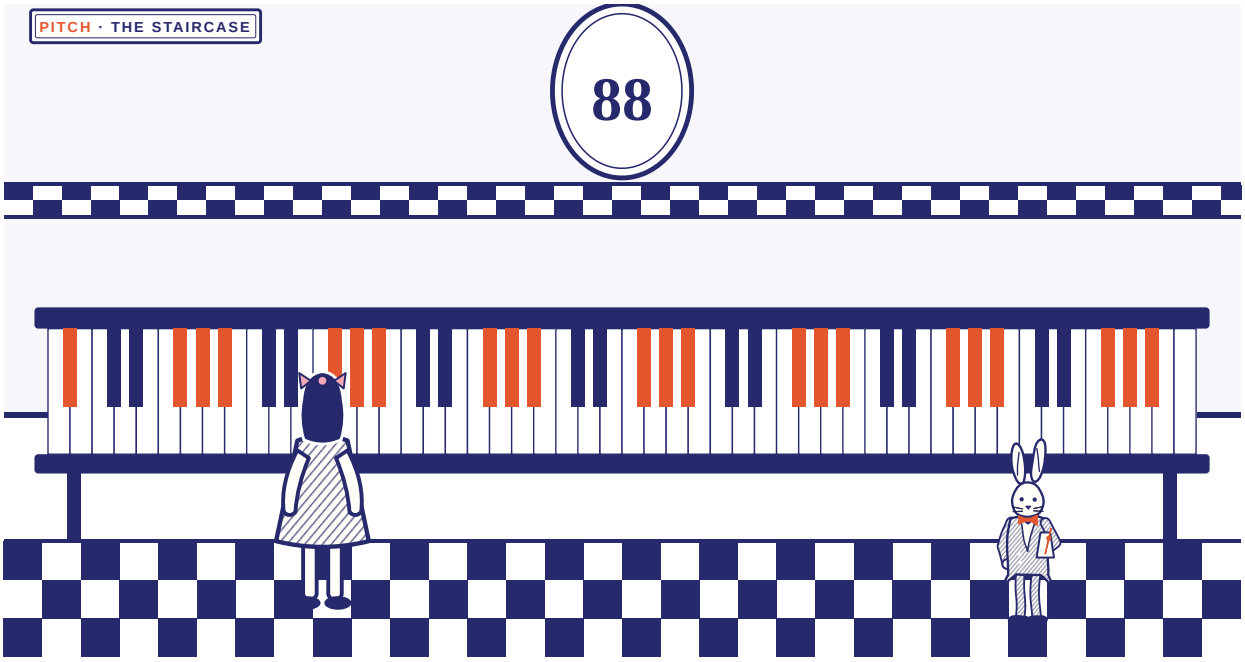
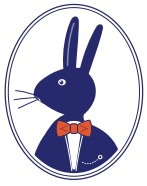


Plate II. Clara loses count somewhere after forty.



Clara tries to count the keys. She loses count somewhere after forty, and starts again, and loses count again.

“There are eighty-eight,” says the Butler, “but nobody finds a key by counting.”

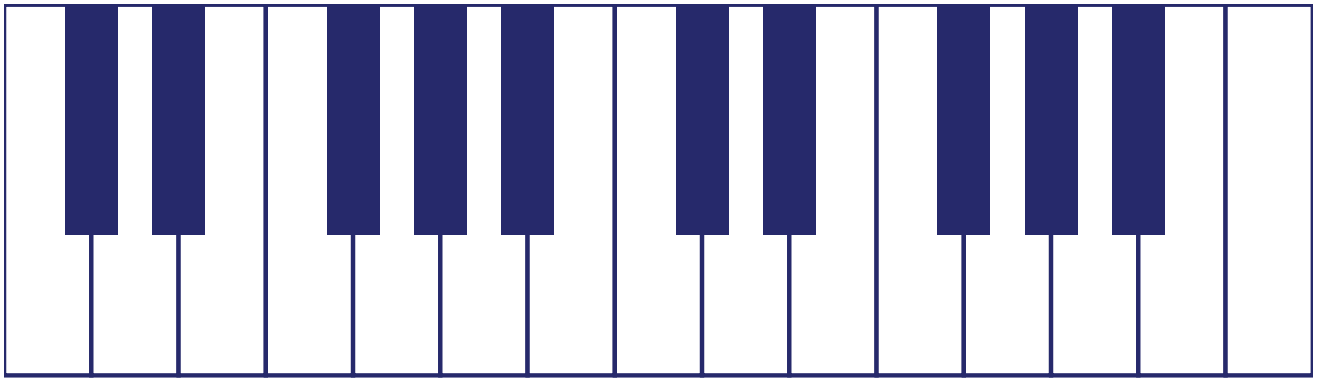
Try it at the piano

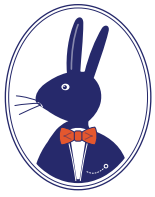
1 Look at the black keys without playing. What do you notice about how they are grouped?

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

The keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN





Look at the black keys. They come in **twos** and **threes**, again and again, all the way along.

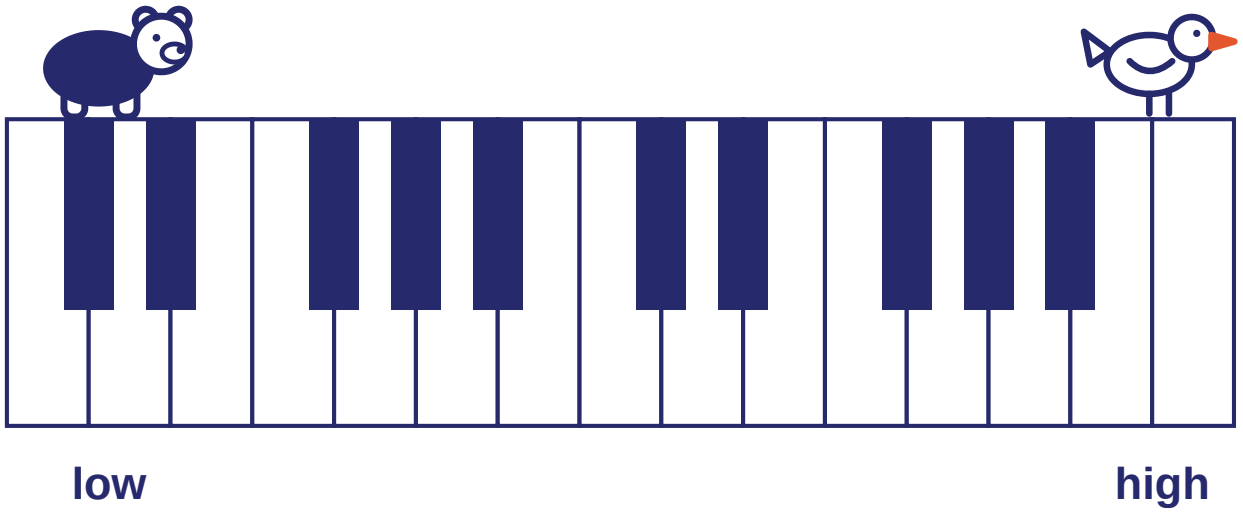
Find the pattern once and you can never get lost.

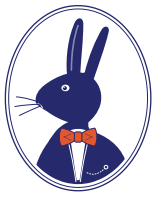
Try it at the piano

1 Touch every group of two black keys, from the left end to the right end. Then every group of three.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

The keyboard





Left is low, like a big grumpy bear. **Right is high**, like a little bird.

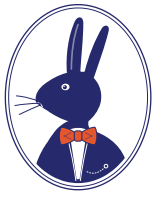
Go to the right and every key sounds a little higher.

Try it at the piano

1. Play the lowest key you can reach, then the highest. Bear, then bird. ○

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

The keyboard



Every white key has a letter. Beside the **two** black keys live **C, D, E**. Beside the **three** live **F, G, A, B**.

After B comes C again: seven letters, round and round.

Try it at the piano

1. Find a group of two black keys. Play the three white keys around it and say C, D, E.

ROOM 2 · HOW IT ENDED

The keyboard

Plate II. Mozart's piano was a good deal smaller.

Mozart's piano had only about five octaves. The eighty-eight keys you see came almost a hundred years later.

Yet the black keys were already in their twos and threes. The pattern is older than the piano.

Try it at the piano

1. Find the lowest group of three black keys and the highest. How many groups of three are between them?

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Upstairs, a row of bells began to ring, one after another. Each bell had a number, and one of them was calling for Clara.

ROOM 3 · THE STORY

Finger numbers

HEAR THE STORY

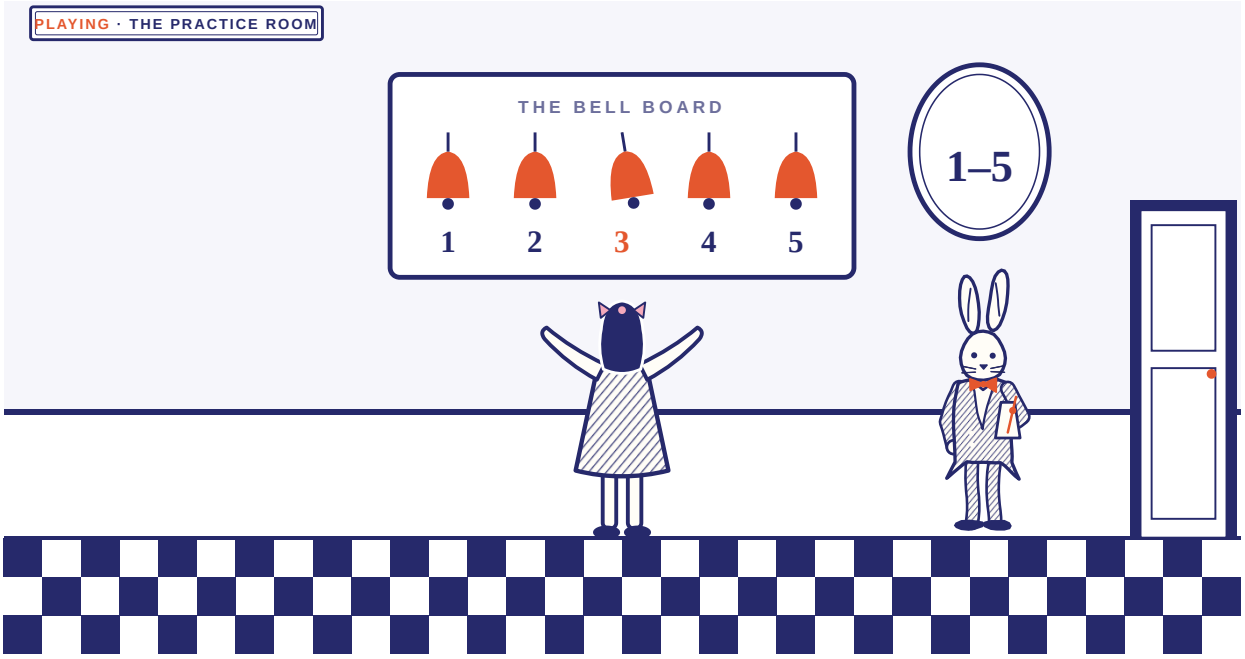
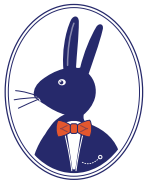


Plate III. The bell board in the practice room, numbered 1 to 5.



On the wall of the practice room hangs an old board of bells, numbered one to five. When a bell rings, everyone in the house knows exactly who is wanted.

Clara's fingers, the Butler explains, work the same way.

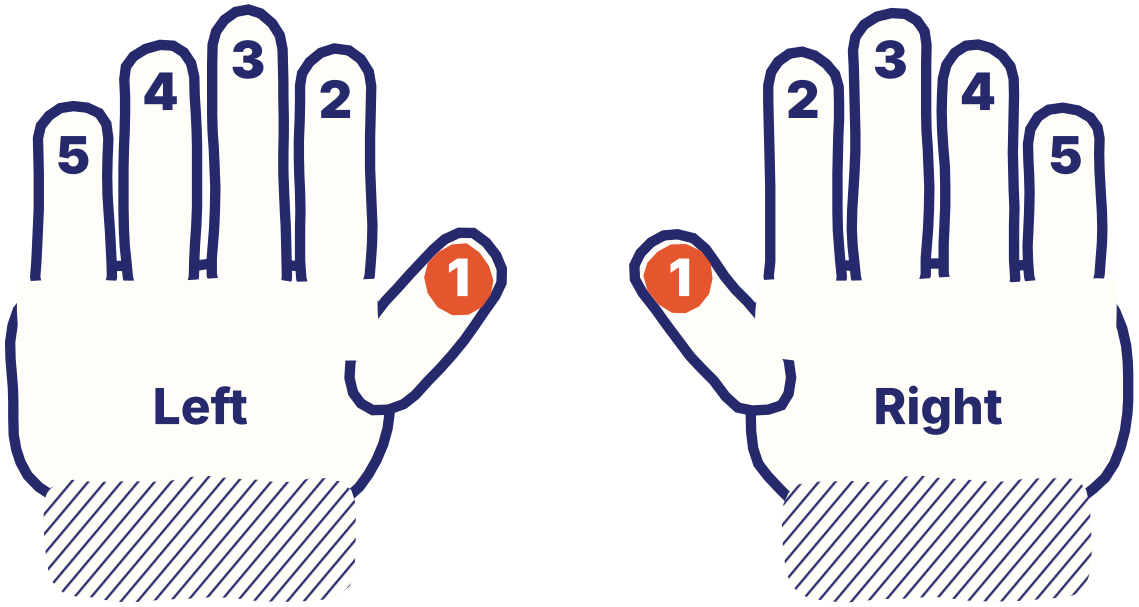
Try it

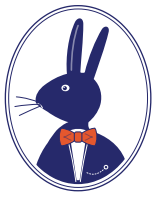
1. Hold up both hands. Ask someone to call a number, and wiggle that finger on both hands.

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

Finger numbers

SCAN TO LISTEN





Every finger has a **number**. The **thumb is 1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**.

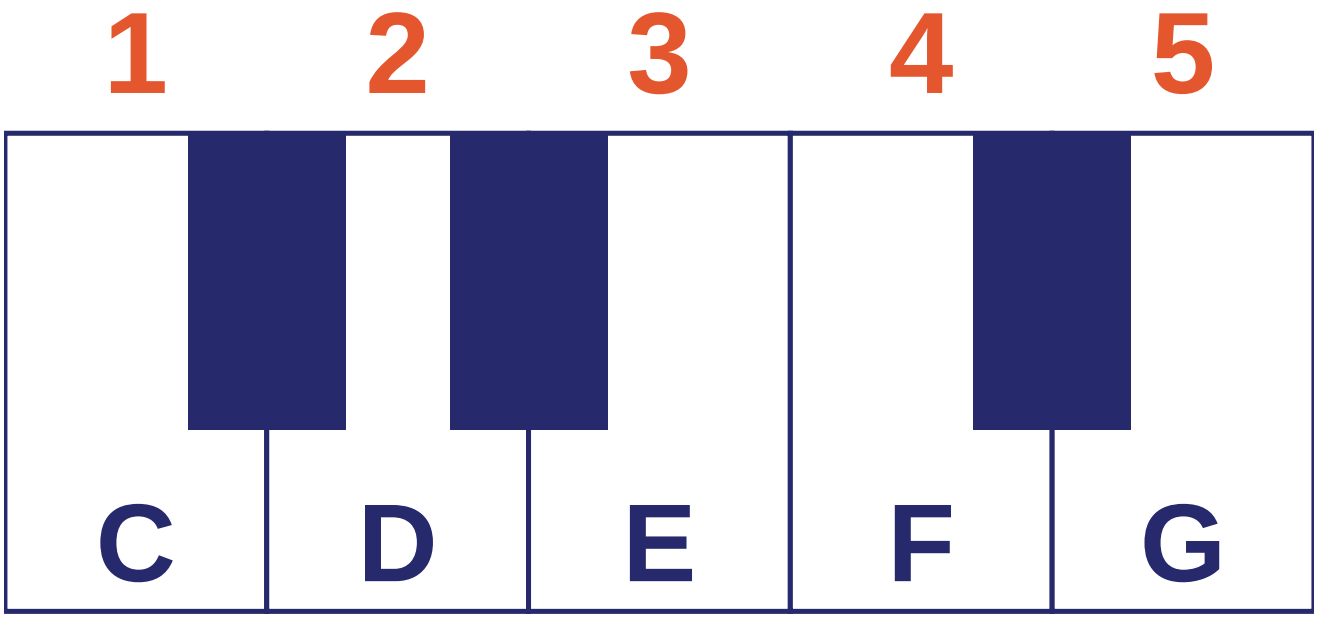
It is the same in both hands: thumbs are always 1.

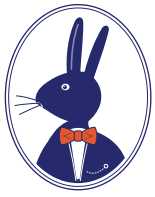
Try it

1. Hold up both hands. Wiggle finger 1, then 2, 3, 4, 5, saying the numbers.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

Finger numbers





Find any **C**: the white key just left of two black keys. Put your right thumb on it. Now **C D E F G** are fingers **1 2 3 4 5**.

In the left hand the little finger starts: C D E F G are **5 4 3 2 1**.

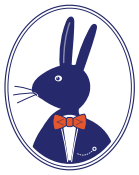
Try it at the piano

1. Right thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers. Then the left hand, starting with finger 5.

ROOM 3 · HOW IT ENDED

Finger numbers

Plate III. The English way: a cross for the thumb.



Fingers were not always numbered this way. In old English music the thumb was marked with a **cross**, and the fingers were 1, 2, 3, 4.

The way you learn, thumb as 1, won in the end.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C D E F G with your right hand, saying the numbers. Then say them the old English way: cross, 1, 2, 3, 4.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Then the Butler handed her the key to the next floor. "Mind the Queen," he said. "And whatever you do, do not sit in the King's chair."

ROOM 4 · THE STORY

The staff and the clefs

HEAR THE STORY

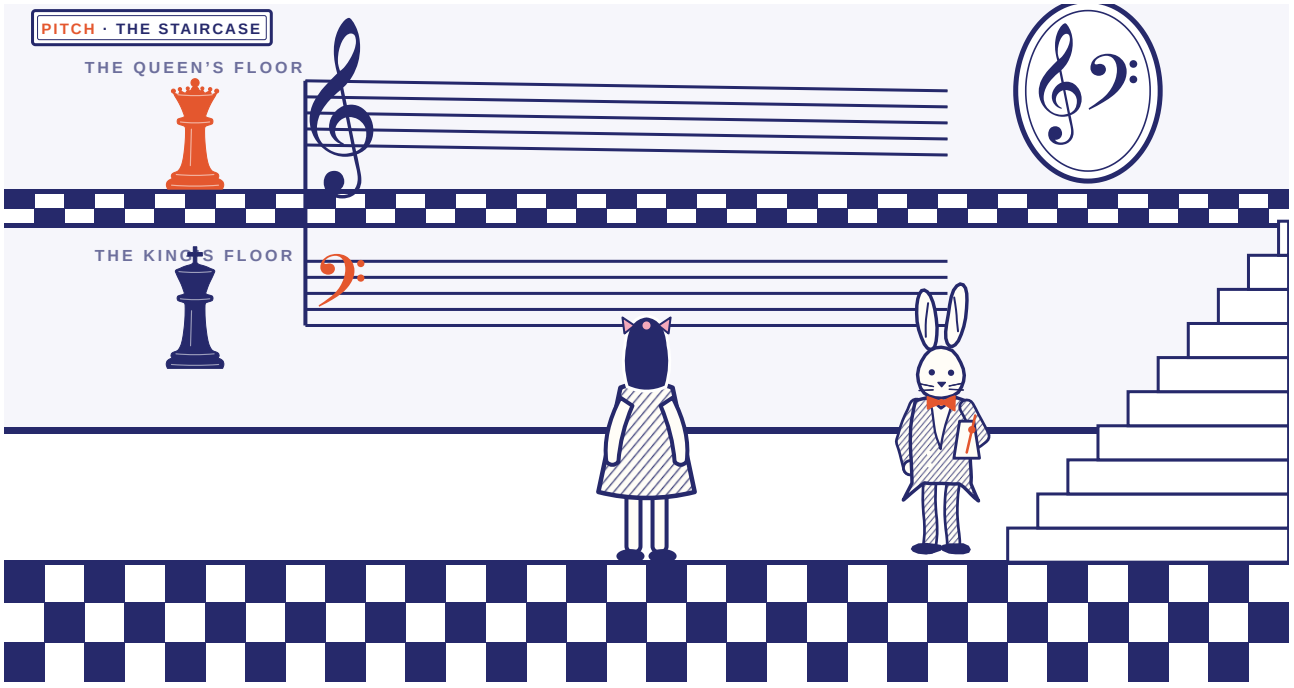
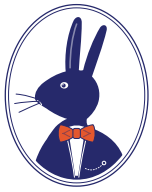


Plate IV. The Queen and the King, each with a floor of their own.



Two people own the lines in this house. The **Queen** rules the high floor, the **King** the low one.

Each has a sign at the start of the floor, and they are very particular about it.

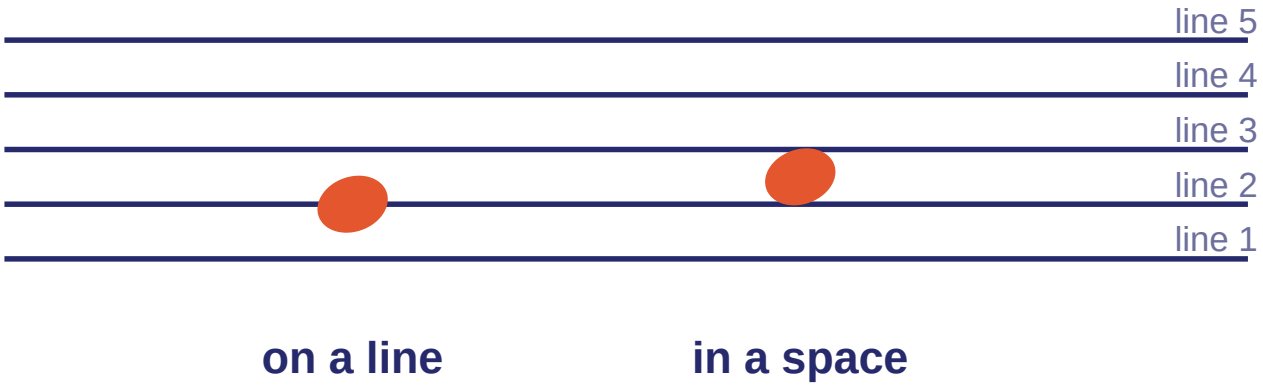
Try it at the piano

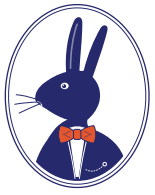
1. Play a high note and say “the Queen’s floor”. Play a low note and say “the King’s floor”.

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 2

The staff and the clefs

SCAN TO LISTEN





Music is written on **five lines**, called the **staff**.

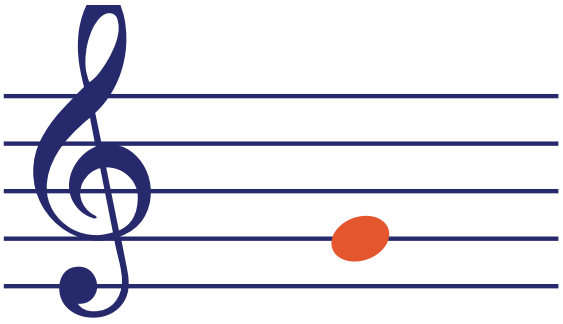
A note can sit **on a line**. Or it can sit **in a space**. Higher up means higher on the piano.

Try it

1. Count the lines from the bottom: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Then count the four spaces.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 2

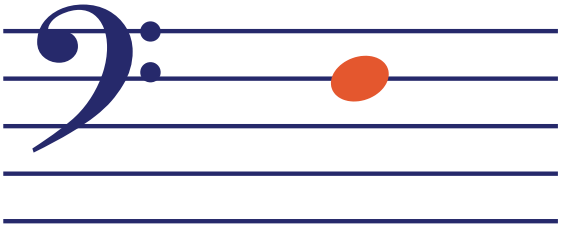
The staff and the clefs



G

Treble clef

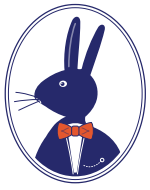
the Queen · her curl holds the G line



F

Bass clef

the King · his dots hug the F line



A **clef** at the start says which notes the lines stand for.

The **treble clef** is the Queen of the high notes: her curl wraps round the line for **G**. The **bass clef** is the King of the low notes: his two dots hug the line for **F**.

Try it at the piano

1. Play any high key with your right hand: the Queen's side. Then any low key with your left: the King's side.

ROOM 4 · HOW IT ENDED

The staff and the clefs

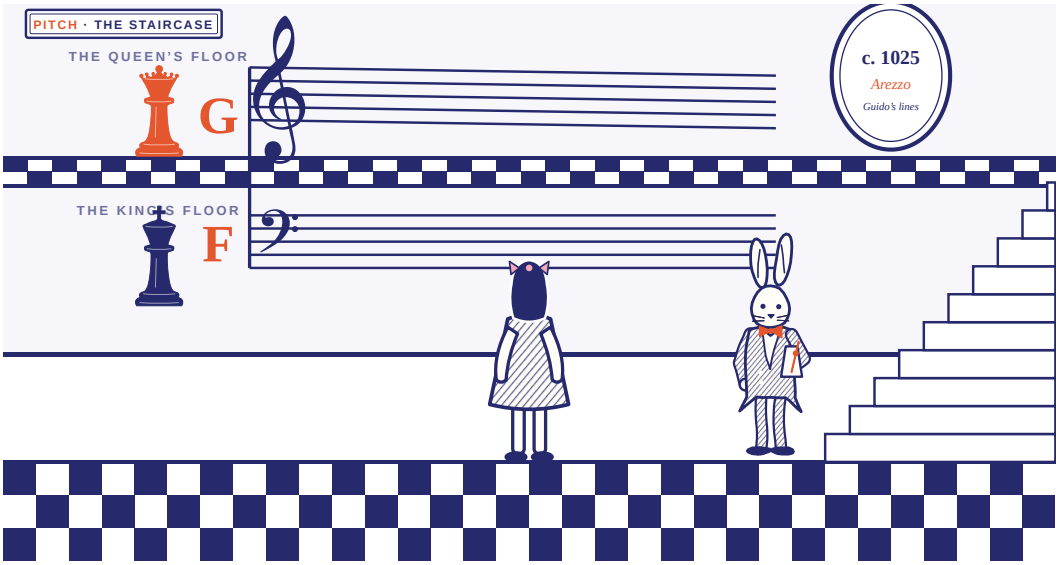


Plate IV. A monk, a few lines, and a better memory.

About a thousand years ago a monk called **Guido** wanted his singers to learn songs faster. He arranged lines a third apart, and put each note on a line or in a space.

Clefs began as plain letters written at the start of a line: F and C at first, G a little later. Over the years the letters curled into the signs you see today.

Try it

1. Draw the letter G and then a treble clef next to it. Can you find the G hiding inside the clef? Then try F and the bass clef.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

Downstairs, the great clock in the hall stopped. For the first time in a hundred years, the house went quiet.

ROOM 5 · THE STORY

The beat

HEAR THE STORY

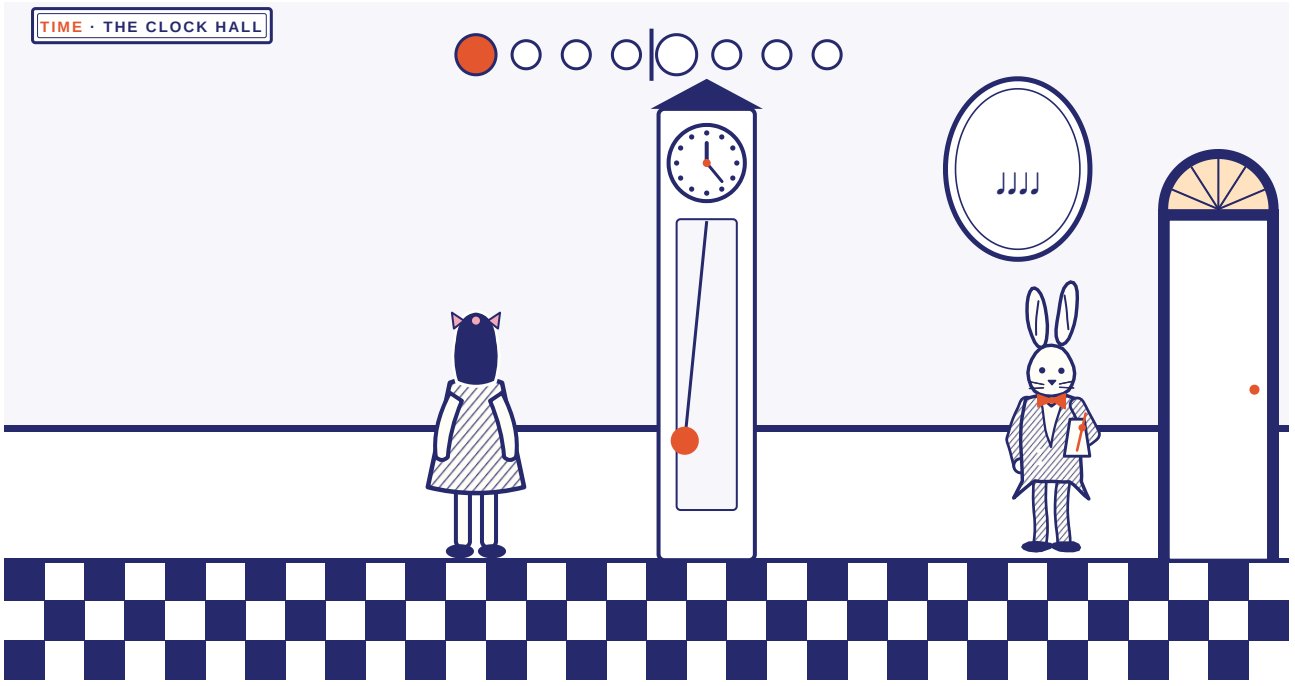
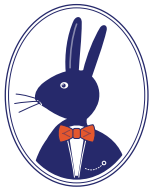


Plate V. The hall clock, which has never once been late.



In the hall stands a clock that has never been late, not once. Tick, tick, tick: never faster, never slower.

"Music has a clock inside it too," says the Butler. "We call it the **beat**."

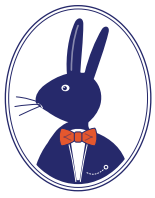
Try it

1. Listen to a clock or your own heartbeat. Tap along on your knee without stopping.

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 2

The beat

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music has a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat. It never speeds up and never stops.

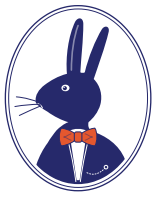
We count the beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, and round again.

Try it

1. Put a hand on your heart. Tap that steady beat on your knee and count 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 2

The beat



Bar lines put the beats into groups called **bars**.
Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest.

Sometimes a beat is **silent**. You still count it.

Try it

1. Clap three in a bar: STRONG, weak, weak. Then leave out one clap, but keep counting.

ROOM 5 · HOW IT ENDED

The beat

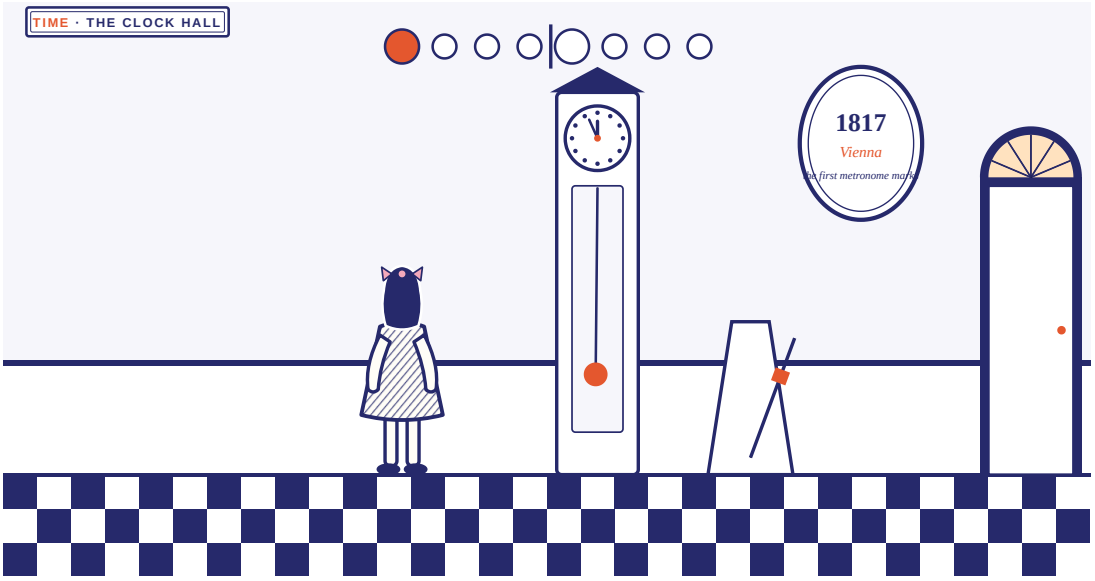


Plate V. Mr Beethoven's first metronome marks.

A man named **Maelzel** sold a ticking machine to keep the beat: the **metronome**. (A Dutchman called Winkel had built it first, but Maelzel's name was on the box.) **Beethoven** was one of the first composers to write its numbers on his music.

The clock in the hall would have approved.

Try it

1. Clap a steady beat while someone counts to twenty. Did you stay with them all the way?

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

When the clock started again, two strangers were waiting in the hall. One was in a terrible hurry. The other refused to move.

ROOM 6 · THE STORY

Notes: crotchet and minim

HEAR THE STORY

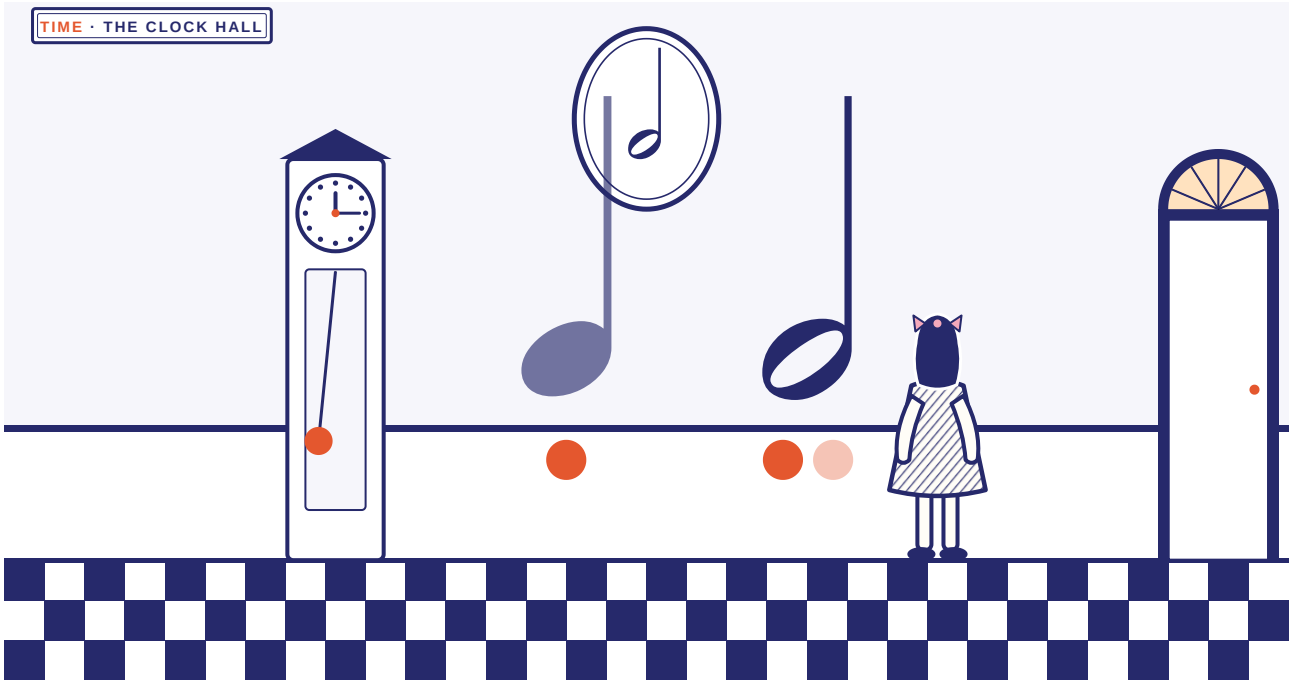
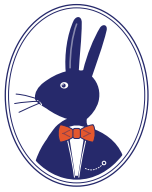


Plate VI. A quick note and a slow one, meeting in the hall.



Two notes meet in the hall. One is gone in a single tick. The other **waits**, and waits, for two.

Clara wonders why the slow one is called a **minim**, which sounds rather small.

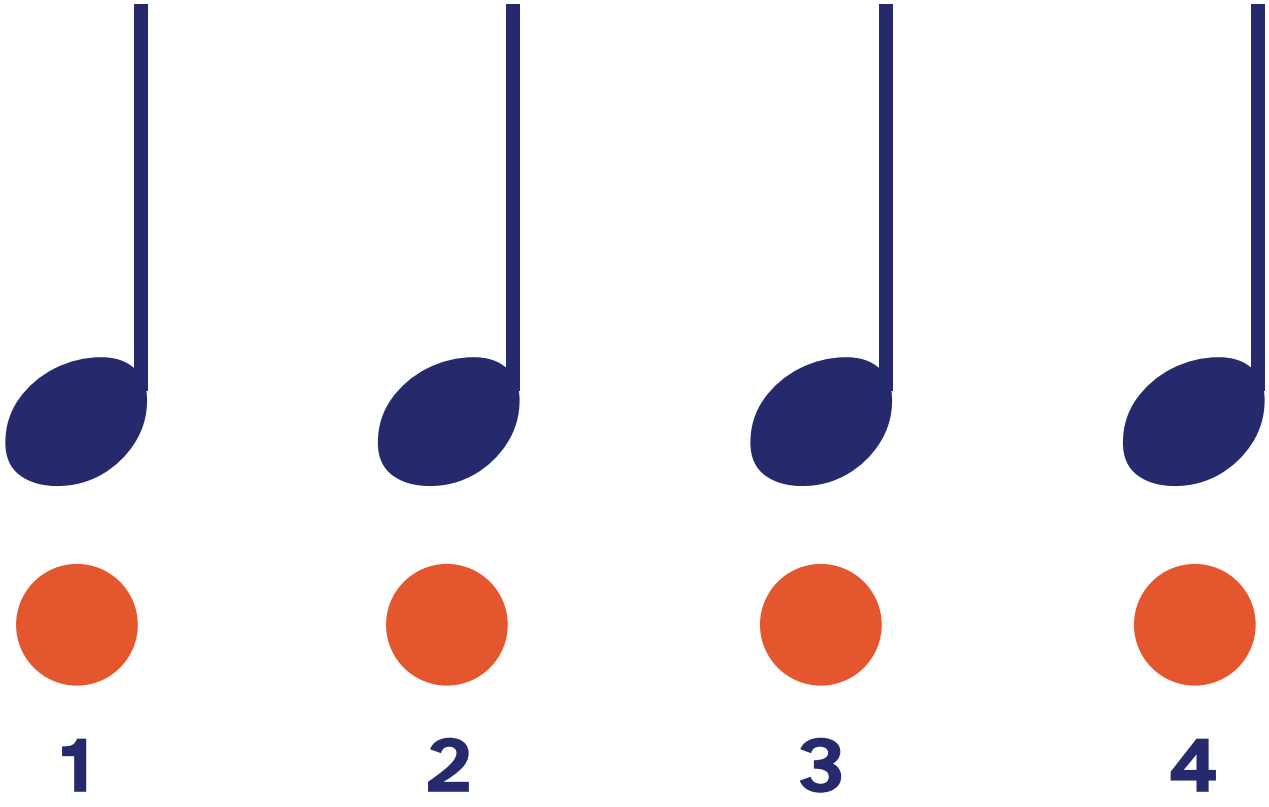
Try it at the piano

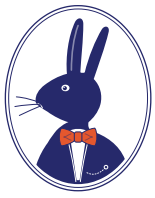
1. Play a note for one beat, then one for two beats. Which one feels longer?

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim

SCAN TO LISTEN





This is a **crotchet**. It lasts **one beat**. One circle under a note means one beat.

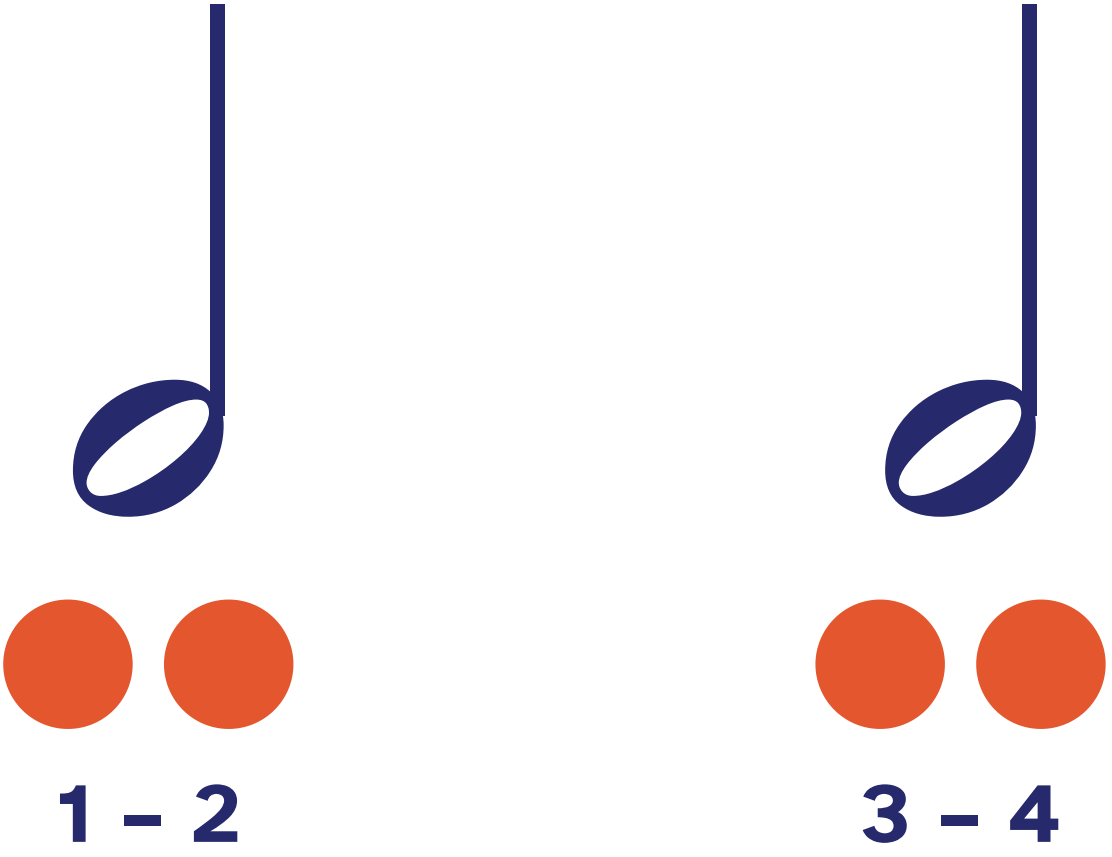
Four crotchets fill a bar of four: play, play, play, play.

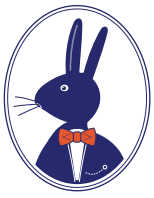
Try it at the piano

1 Play C four times, one for each beat, counting 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim





This is a **minim**. Its head is empty, and it lasts **two beats**.

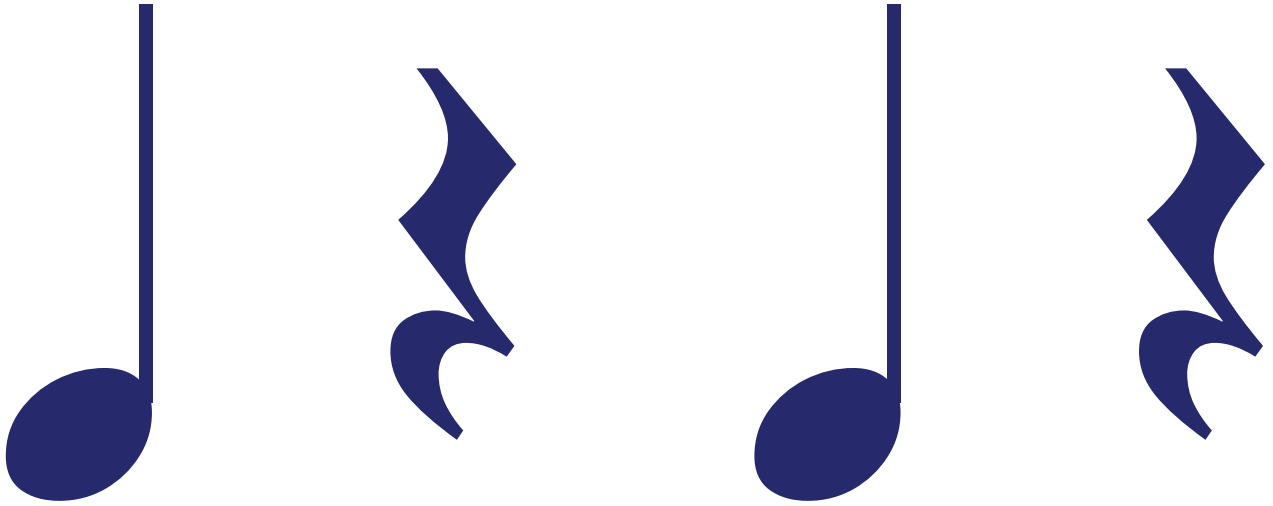
Play on the first beat and **hold** through the second.

Try it at the piano

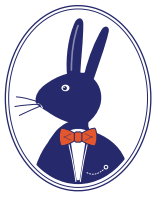
1. Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Then again on 3, holding through 4.

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim



play shh play shh



Silence has signs too, called **rests**. A **crotchet rest** is one beat of silence.

You count a rest just like a note. You just do not play.

Try it at the piano

1. Play, shh, play, shh: C on beats 1 and 3, silence on 2 and 4. Keep counting.

ROOM 6 · HOW IT ENDED

Notes: crotchet and minim

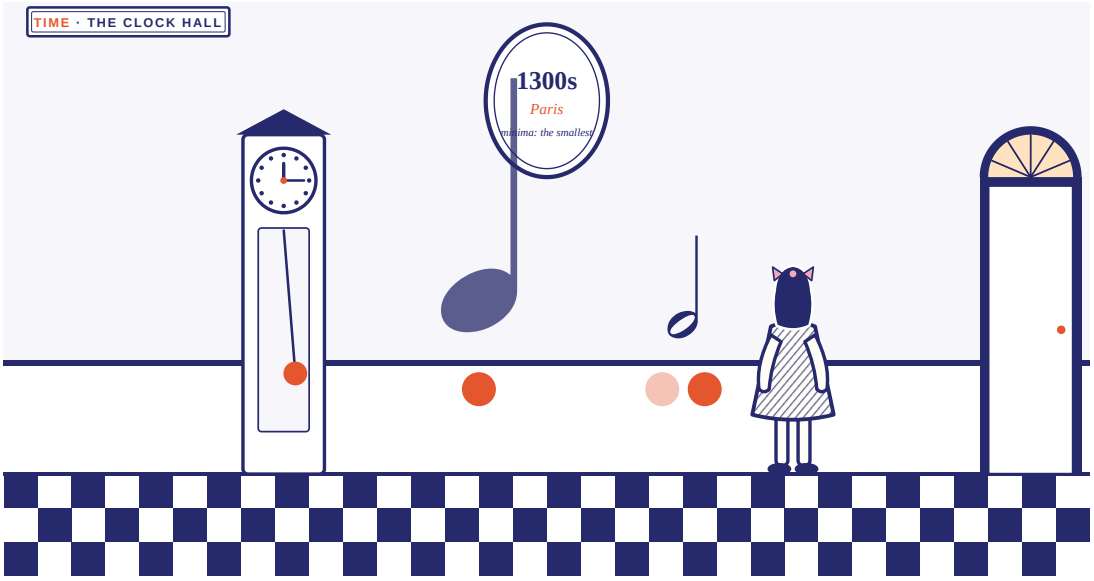


Plate VI. “Minima”, the smallest, which is no longer true.

Seven hundred years ago the **minim** was one of the **shortest** notes there was. Its name comes from the Latin *minima*, the smallest.

Over the centuries composers kept inventing shorter notes, the old ones grew slower and slower, and the name stayed behind. Now the minim is one of the long ones.

Try it at the piano

1. Play four crotchets and then two minims on C. Which of them would once have been the quick notes?

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

And someone had left a single dot on the stairs. The Butler picked it up very carefully, as if it might go off.

ROOM 7 · THE STORY

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve

HEAR THE STORY

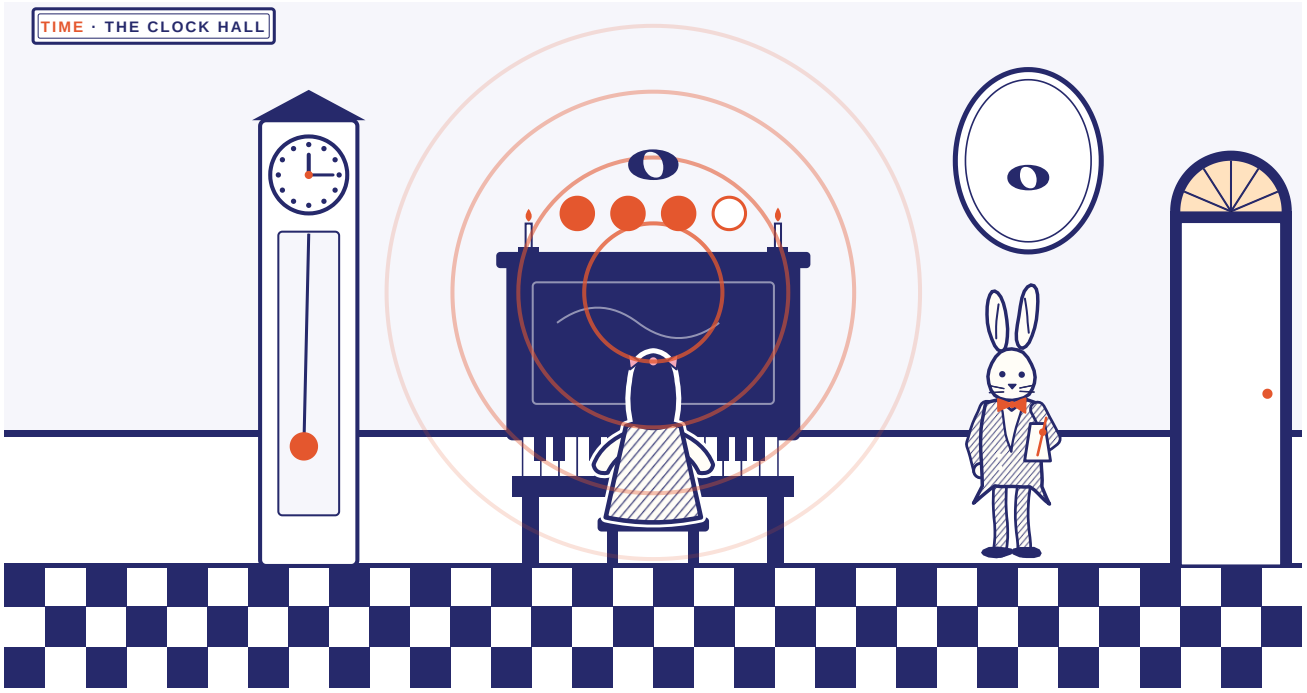
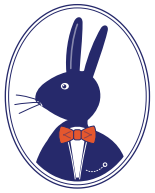


Plate VII. The clock strikes four. Clara is still holding the same note.



The clock strikes four, and Clara is still holding her note. She has pressed only once.

"That," says the Butler, "is a note that takes up the whole bar."

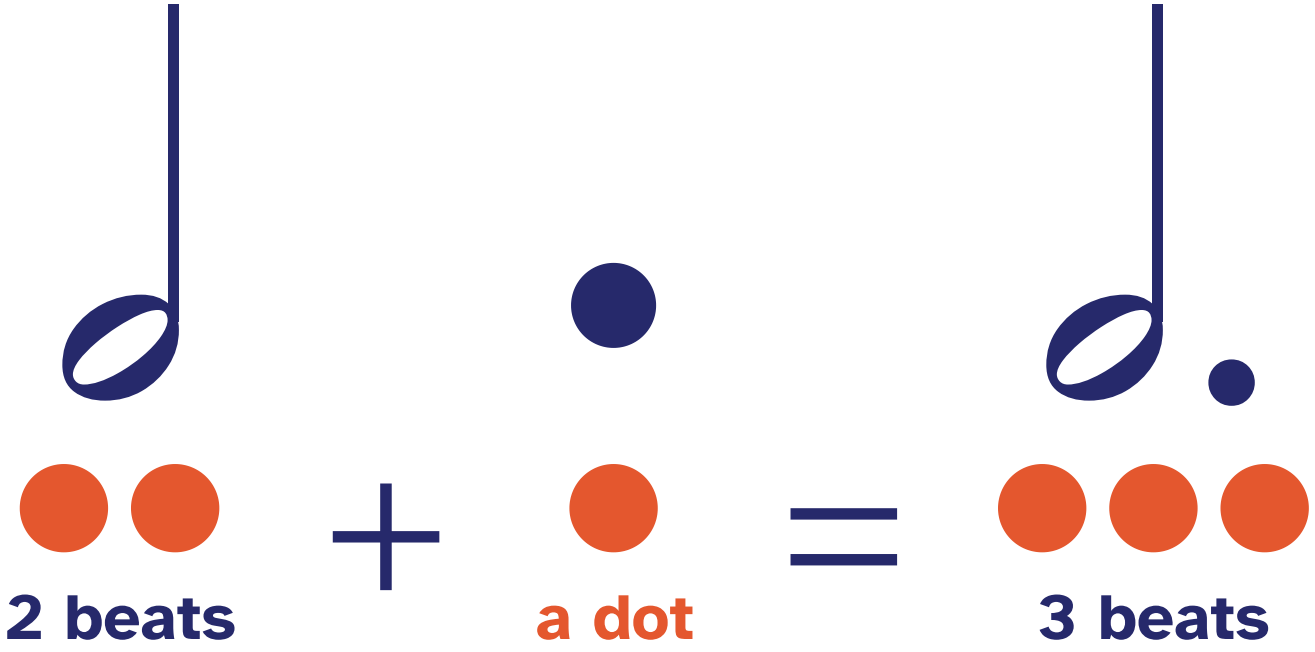
Try it at the piano

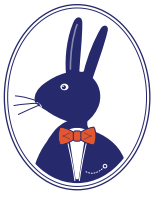
1. Press one key and hold it while you count four slow beats. Did the sound last?

ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve

SCAN TO LISTEN





A **dot** after a minim adds one more beat.

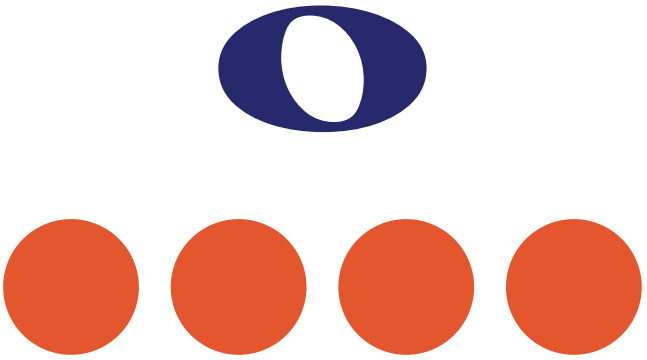
Two beats and one more: a **dotted minim** lasts **three beats**.

Try it at the piano

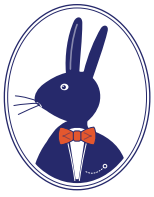
1 Play C and hold for 1 2 3. Play beat 1 a little stronger.

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve



1 – 2 – 3 – 4



This is a **semibreve**: an empty head and no stem. It lasts **four beats**, a whole bar of four.

Press once, and listen until the sound has had all four beats.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Lift exactly when the next bar begins.

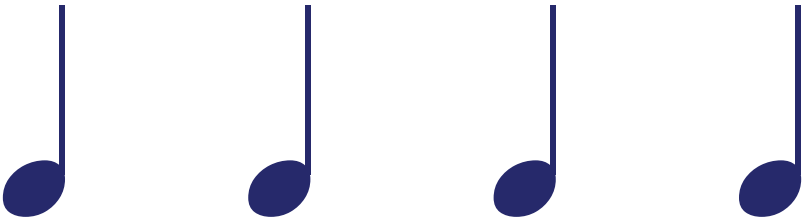
ROOM 7 · STEP 3 OF 3

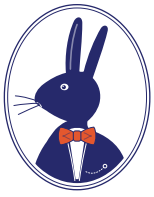
Notes: dotted minim and semibreve

1 semibreve

2 minims

4 crotchets





Now you know the family. Each note is **half** of the one above it.

One semibreve is as long as two minims, or four crotchets.

Try it at the piano

1. Play four crotchets on C. Then one semibreve, held for all four beats. The same length!

ROOM 7 · HOW IT ENDED

Notes: dotted minim and semibreve

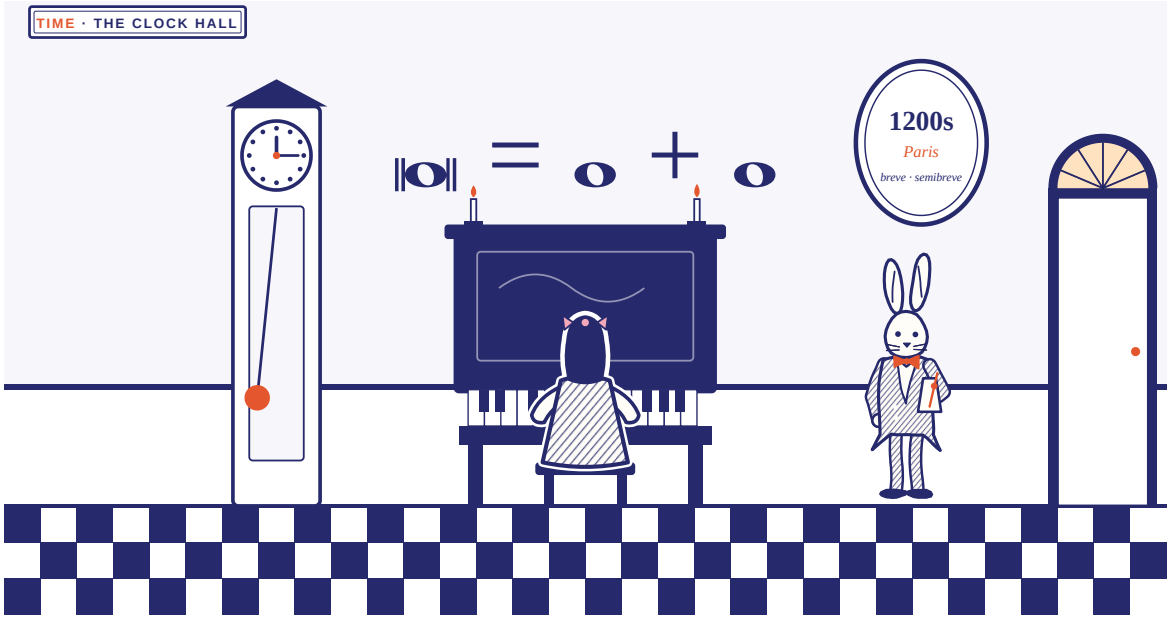
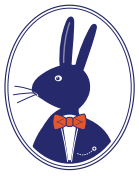


Plate VII. Half of something that used to be short.



Semibreve means “half a breve”, and *breve* means short. The breve used to be a short note.

Like the minim, it grew longer over the years. Today the breve is so long that you hardly ever see it.

Try it at the piano

1. Play a semibreve on C and count 1 2 3 4. Imagine a note twice as long: that is a breve.

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

On Thursday there would be the music evening. Clara had her piece ready. Nobody had told her how loud to play it.

ROOM 8 · THE STORY

Loud and soft

HEAR THE STORY

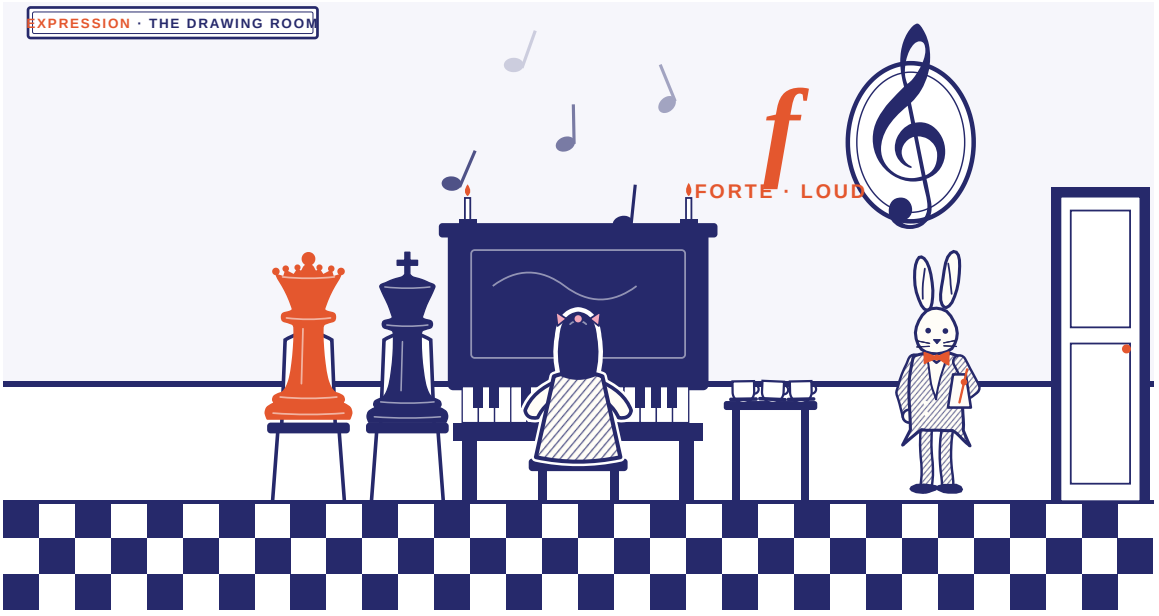


Plate VIII. The music evening, forte.

On Thursday the house holds its **music evening**. Clara plays her first piece with every note at full strength: ***forte***, loud and strong.

The music marches round the room like a parade. The cups ring on their saucers, the Queen sits up very straight, and the King taps his foot. The Butler sets down the tray. “Splendid,” he says. “Now the same piece, *piano*.”

Try it at the piano

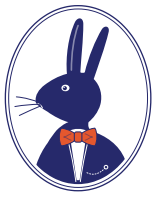
1. Play C forte, like the start of a parade: a heavy arm, a full sound. Then play it piano, like a secret.

ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN

p soft ***f*** loud



Music can be **soft** or **loud**. The signs are Italian: ***p*** for *piano*, soft, and ***f*** for *forte*, loud.

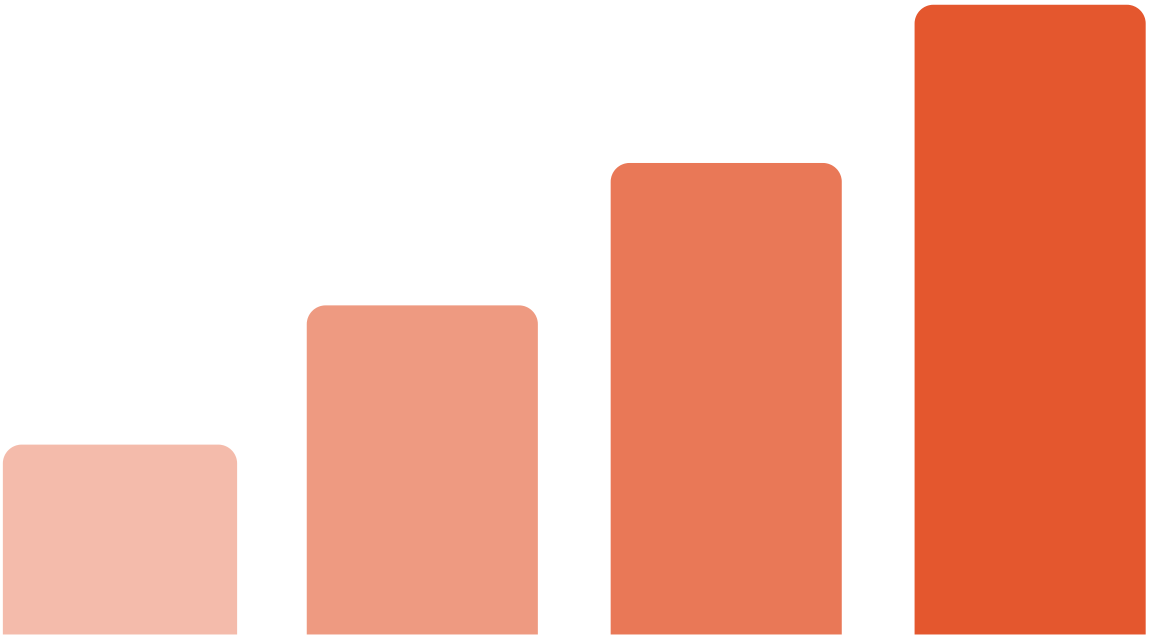
To play louder, let your arm feel heavy. Do not hit the key.

Try it at the piano

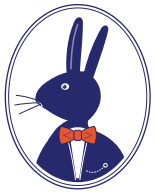
1 Play C softly, like a secret. Then play it loudly, like calling across a field.

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Loud and soft



p	*mp*	*mf*	*f*
soft	quite soft	quite loud	loud



Between soft and loud come two more signs. The ***m*** is for *mezzo*, which means **half** or **medium**: ***mp*** is quite soft, ***mf*** is quite loud.

Soft does not mean slow, and loud does not mean fast. The beat stays the same.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. ○

ROOM 8 · HOW IT ENDED

Loud and soft

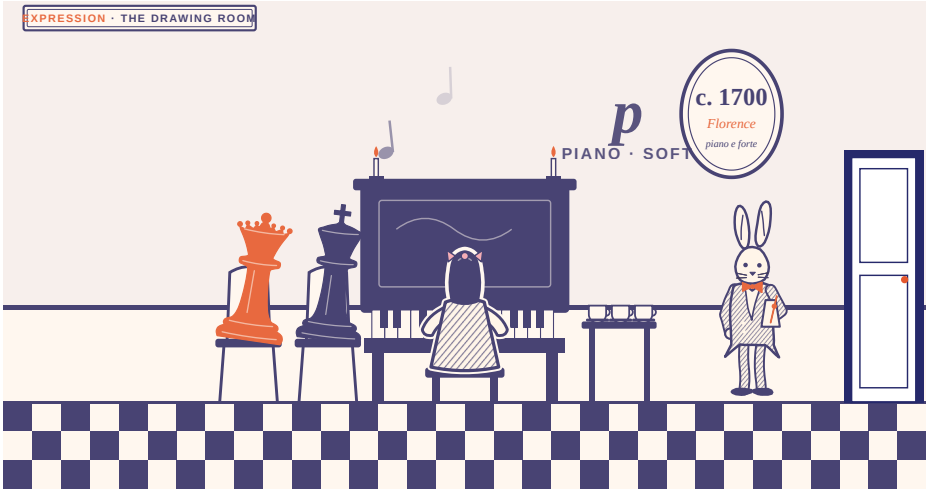


Plate VIII. The same piece, piano.

So Clara plays it again, ***piano***: soft, her fingers close to the keys, her arms light. The room changes. The candles seem to stand still, and the Queen and the King lean **forward** to listen.

Forte made the piece a parade. Piano made it a secret, told to one person. The same notes can tell **two different stories**: that is what loud and soft are for.

The instrument is named after this. Around 1700 in Florence, **Bartolomeo Cristofori** built a keyboard that could play both: a harpsichord *col piano e forte*, with soft and loud. We still call it the piano.

Try it at the piano

1. Play a tune you know twice: once forte, once piano. Which story does each one tell?

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

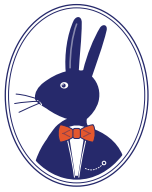
After the evening, someone began to play behind a closed door. Clara could not see who. She would have to listen.

ROOM 9 · THE STORY

Ear training

HEAR THE STORY

Plate IX. Someone is playing behind the door.



Someone is playing in the next room, and the door is shut. Clara presses her ear to it.

High or low? The same tune as before, or a new one? Here she cannot see the keys. She can only **listen**.

Try it at the piano

1. Close your eyes. Ask someone to play two notes. Was the second one higher or lower?

ROOM 9 · LISTEN

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

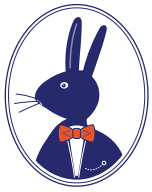
1 Low, middle or high?

2 Same clapping, or different?

3 Same tune, or different?

4 Which way did it go?

5 Find the note



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Five listening games are waiting in the app. Scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1. Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

ROOM 9 · HOW IT ENDED

Ear training

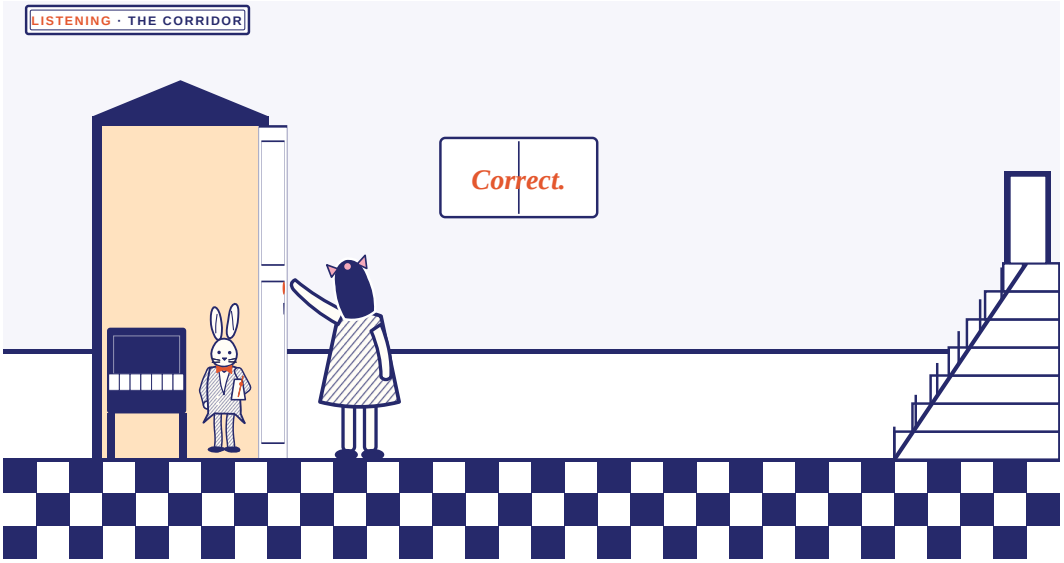


Plate IX. The player behind the door.

When the playing stops, Clara opens the door. There sits the **Butler** at the old practice piano, one finger still on a key.

"High, then low," says Clara. "And the same tune twice." The Butler writes one word in his book: *Correct*. Good pianists listen first. The ear tells the fingers where to go.

Try it at the piano

1. Face the wall. Ask someone to play a high note or a low one. Say which, then turn round and check. ○

BEHIND THE NEXT DOOR

At the top of the stairs Clara found a door she had never noticed. On it, in gold letters: PRELIM. Inside, someone was practising the same bar, again and again.